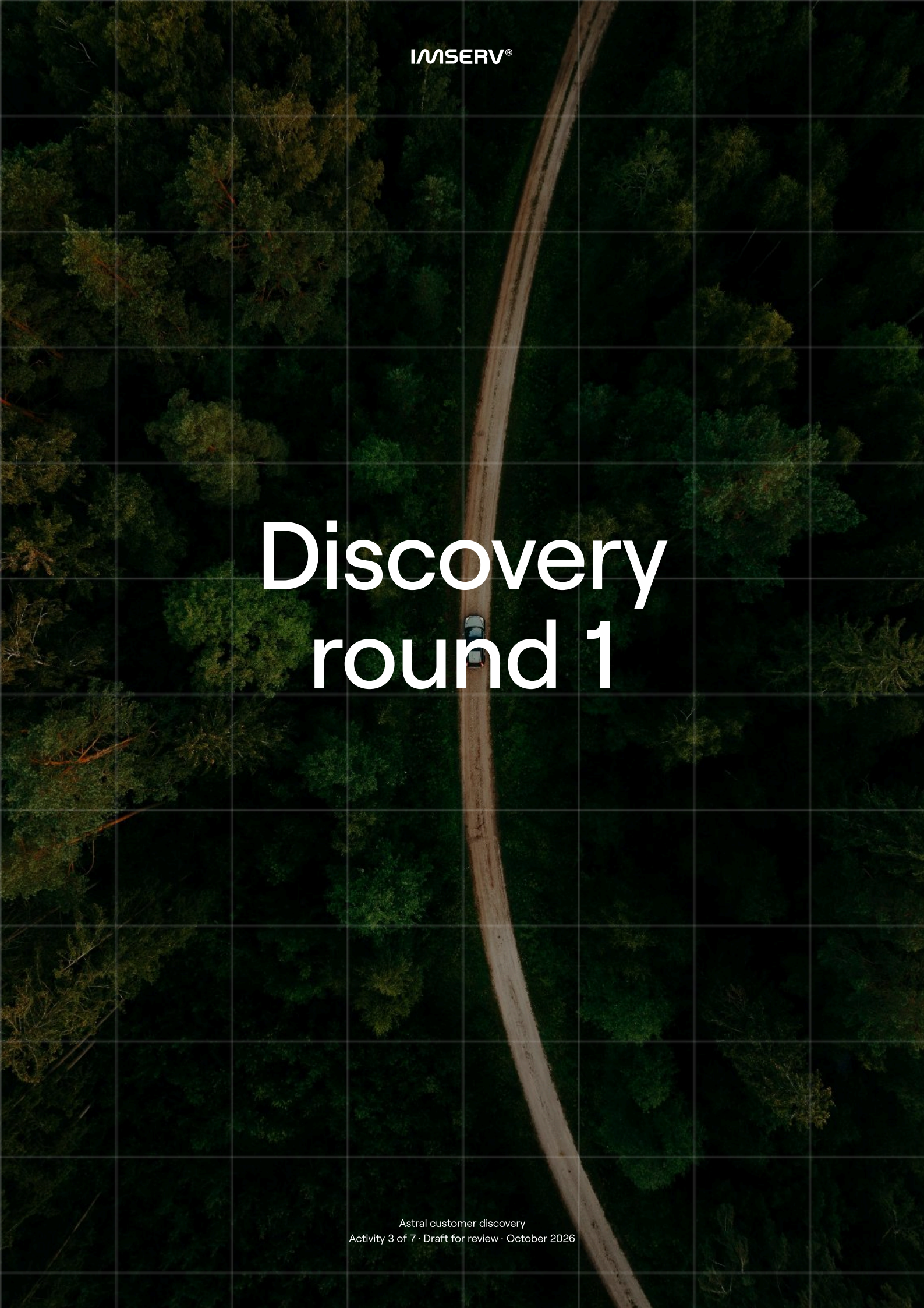
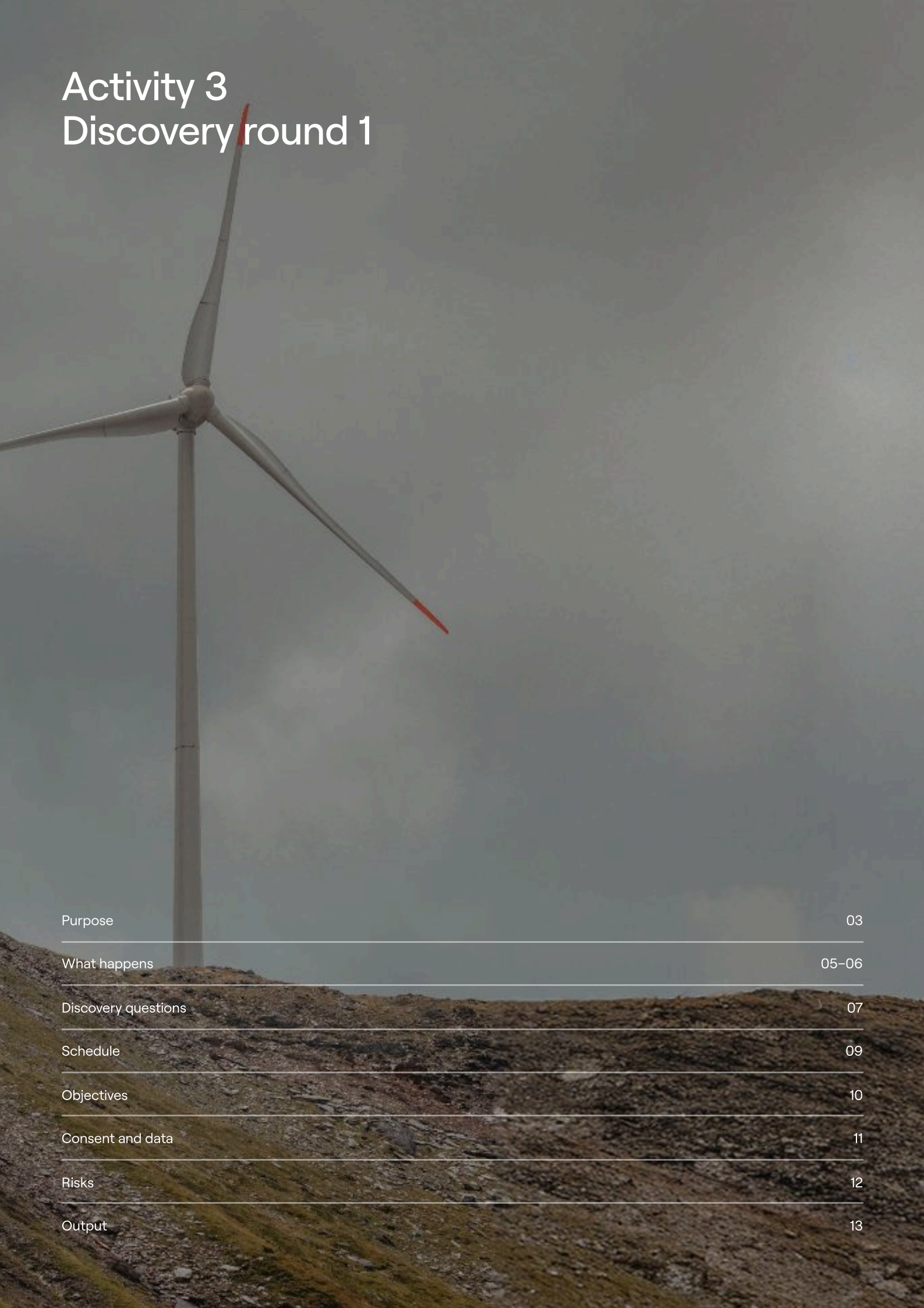
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Discovery round 1

Astral customer discovery
Activity 3 of 7 · Draft for review · October 2026

Activity 3
Discovery round 1



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ACTIVITY 3 OF 7

Discovery round 1

Understand real, recent episodes of work before showing any proposed screens.

PROVISIONAL DURATION

2 to 3 weeks, including analysis

DEPENDS ON

Bookings

OUTPUT

Episode-level evidence, first journey fragments, candidate behaviours, and recruitment gaps.

OBJECTIVES IT SERVES

- 1. **Understand** how customers do their energy-data work today, from trigger to finished outcome, including spreadsheets, email, and other tools.
- 2. **Identify** recurring behavioural patterns that need different design priorities or trade-offs.
- 3. **Understand** what people check before they trust and share a figure or a report.
- 4. **Identify** who does, approves, and receives the work, and where handoffs and waiting happen.
- 5. **Determine** where problems come from the service, process, or data rather than the interface.

THE SEVEN ACTIVITIES

1	Agree scope and decisions
2	Set up recruitment
3	**Discovery round 1**
4	Discovery round 2, targeted
5	Survey
6	Integrate and follow up
7	Test design implications

PRIMARY RESEARCH QUESTION

How do IMSERV customers do their energy-data work today, and which differences in that work should change how Astral is designed and prioritised?

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What happens

What happens

Proposed 60-minute remote sessions. Interview plus a walkthrough of a recent piece of work. 6 to 8 participants across several organisations.

1

Ask about the last real time

We ask about the last real time, not about features. Then we follow that episode through its tools, decisions, and handoffs.

2

Walk through a recent piece of work

Where it is appropriate and authorised, participants show a redacted report, spreadsheet, email chain, or output.

3

No prototype screens

We do not show prototype screens in discovery. A prototype steers the conversation towards its own features.

4

Analyse

Code against objectives, then open coding. Separate observation from interpretation. Look for contradictions and outliers.

Sample this round

Two rounds of 6 to 8 is a starting proposal, not a promise of coverage. Plan rounds, not a total.

Participants across several organisations

6–8

60 minutes each
Remote, proposed

“Tell me about the last time you needed to investigate a figure that did not look right. What triggered it, and what happened next?”

Discovery questions

We ask about the last real time, not about features. Then we follow that episode through its tools, decisions, and handoffs.

Area	Discovery questions
Trigger and outcome	What started the work? What had to be achieved?
Actual process	What did you do first? What happened after that?
Evidence and trust	What did you check before relying on the result?
Tools and workarounds	What left the portal? What happened in a spreadsheet or email?
Collaboration	Who contributed, approved, or acted? What information did they need?
Difficulty and consequences	Where did it slow down? What happened when it went wrong?
Completion	How did you know it was finished, not just sent to someone else?

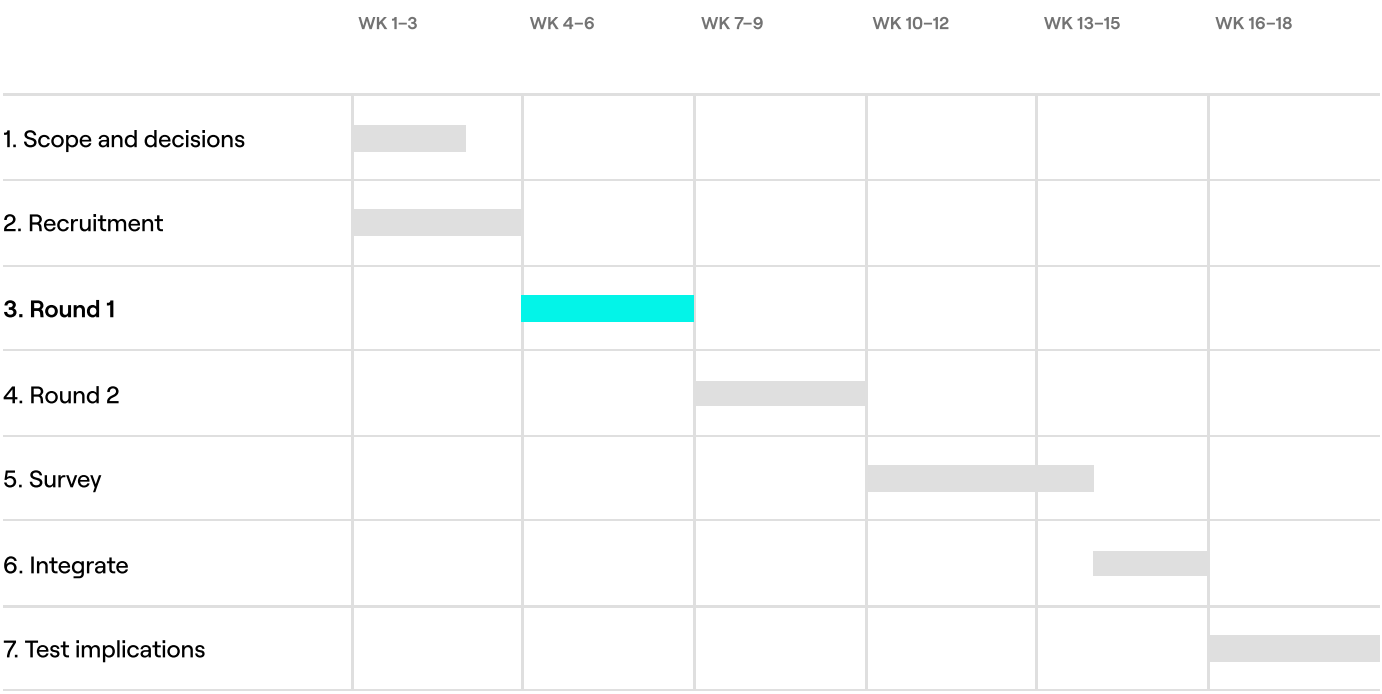
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Plan and safeguards

Where it sits

Estimates to agree, not commitments. Bars show the upper estimate for each stage. With overlap, roughly 12 to 18 weeks from agreement to tested implications.



Stage	Provisional duration	Depends on
3. Discovery round 1	2 to 3 weeks, including analysis	Bookings

Objective-to-evidence

How this activity answers the objectives. Measures serve an objective. They are not collected for their own sake.

Objective	Research question	Evidence	Measure
1. Understand	What triggers the work, and what does finished look like?	Episode accounts, artefacts	Journey stages covered per scenario
2. Identify	Which patterns recur across organisations, roles, and scales?	Coded episodes across participants and organisations	Patterns observed in n of N participants and organisations
3. Understand	What do people check before relying on a figure?	Described and shown checks. Reported frequency	Reported frequency among respondents
4. Identify	Who contributes, approves, or acts?	Handoffs, correspondence	Handoffs per journey. Waiting points
5. Determine	Where does it slow down, and why?	Breakdowns traced to cause	Problems classed interface, process, or data

Neutral draft. No consent wording is sent until it is approved. Legal review before it reaches a participant.

Consent, privacy and data

Agreed with IMSERV's privacy and data-protection owner before the first session.

Every session

- Informed consent for every participant before the session
- Recording, transcription, storage, retention, and any AI processing agreed with IMSERV's privacy and data-protection owner before the first session
- Approved storage with restricted access. Raw recordings and transcripts stay restricted
- Customer documents shown in walkthroughs are redacted or not kept, as agreed
- Participants are P01, P02 in analysis. Removing names alone may not anonymise a distinctive business account
- Quotes in shared outputs only with consent for anonymised quotation
- No consent wording is sent until it is approved. The current wording is a neutral draft

How AI is used

Copilot can help organise approved material, suggest candidate patterns, and keep evidence links up to date. Only within what the privacy owner approves.

It will **not** invent quotes, build archetypes from job titles, or treat simulated customers as evidence.

Risks and limits

What could weaken the evidence, and what we do about it.

Risk	Effect	Mitigation
Introductions only reach senior contacts	We hear about the work, not from the people doing it	Ask for practitioners by the activity they do. Track who does what in the screener
Participants come from one or two organisations	Shared local process looks like a pattern	Track organisation coverage. Recruit across several
Prototype screens steer discovery	We confirm our own design	No screens until stage 7

Episode-level evidence, first journey fragments, candidate behaviours, and recruitment gaps.

Output

Early findings reach the BA team from round 1, not only at the end.

Hands over to

Activity 4. Discovery round 2, targeted.

Fill the gaps round 1 found and test our early interpretations.

Working alongside the BA team

- Round 1 findings are shared with the BA team as they emerge, marked provisional
- Stories link back to the need and evidence behind them
- The BA team (Claire and others) can bring open story questions into round 2



Thank You

Shaun Leishman
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